

Sanssouci

A pleasure palace built for Prussia's "enlightened despot," Frederick the Great



ROCOCO FACADE

The main facade of the palace is amusingly enlivened with carved figures of bacchants, the unruly followers of the ancient Roman wine god Bacchus.

King Frederick II of Prussia (r.1740–1786), also known as Frederick the Great, had the small palace of Sanssouci created as a retreat from the burdens of government and warfare—the French phrase *sans souci* means “without worry.” Built between 1745 and 1747 in Potsdam on the outskirts of Berlin, it was designed by court architect Georg Wenzeslaus von Knobelsdorff. The king also played a direct role in the conception and execution of the project. He eventually fell out with Knobelsdorff, and the architect was fired before the building was completed.

Lighter spirit

Sanssouci was designed in the lightweight Rococo style (see pp.164–165), which was the height of fashion in Europe in the mid-18th century. Derived from Baroque but decidedly less ponderous and pompous, Rococo

typically exploited mythological themes to create a world of delightful fantasy. Hedonistic and self-consciously frivolous, it was wholly appropriate to a residence meant for pleasure rather than pompous public display.

Parkland views

The main part of the palace, consisting of 10 principal rooms, is on a single floor. Set upon a hill above a terraced vineyard, the palace is surrounded by parkland dotted with playful, ornamental temples and pavilions. Originally Rococo, the interior was later redecorated in the Neo-Classical style.

Frederick regularly spent his summers at Sanssouci through his lifetime and requested to be buried there on his death. This wish was ignored until 1991, when his remains were brought from Potsdam Garrison Church and interred on the vineyard terrace.

A **dog lover**, Frederick asked to be **buried at Sanssouci** alongside his **favorite greyhounds**



Blenheim Palace

An historic country house designed as a tribute to British war hero the Duke of Marlborough



In 1704, the Duke of Marlborough, who commanded the British army at the Battle of Blenheim, was awarded a grant of royal land in Oxfordshire. He engaged John Vanbrugh, a playwright with little architectural experience, to design a palace. Vanbrugh, along with Nicholas Hawksmoor, had already begun work on an extravagant house in Yorkshire, and Blenheim was to be its equal in grandeur. More a memorial than a home,

Blenheim was built in the English Baroque style. It was set in gardens that were later transformed by the famed landscape architect Lancelot “Capability” Brown.

▽ LAVISH BAROQUE

Vanbrugh designed Blenheim on a grand scale, inspired by the example of the Baroque palaces that were being built in Louis XIV's France.

THE PIANO NOBILE

The palace has the state rooms on the first floor, the *piano nobile*. It is decorated with many paintings celebrating Marlborough's battlefield successes. The chapel houses the sarcophagus in which he and his wife Sarah are interred.

grand saloon great hall

